

Golden flying snake

Chrysopelea ornata

- ↔ 3–4 ft (1–1.2 m)
- 📍 S. and SE. Asia
- ⊗ Not known

Superbly adapted for climbing, this mildly venomous snake uses its underside scales to grip bark and branches—and is capable of scaling near-vertical surfaces. Once it reaches a high perch, it can even launch itself into the air and glide across forest clearings. By spreading its ribs, it pulls its underside to form a U-shape along its length so its body acts like a lengthened parachute.

Milksnake

Lampropeltis triangulum

- ↔ 1–7 ft (0.3–2.1 m)
- 📍 North America, Central America, N. South America
- ⊗ Not known

One of the most widely distributed terrestrial snakes, the milksnake's colors mimic those of the venomous coral snakes—a feature that probably evolved to warn predators to stay away. Milksnakes feed on invertebrates, amphibians, and small rodents.

smooth scales

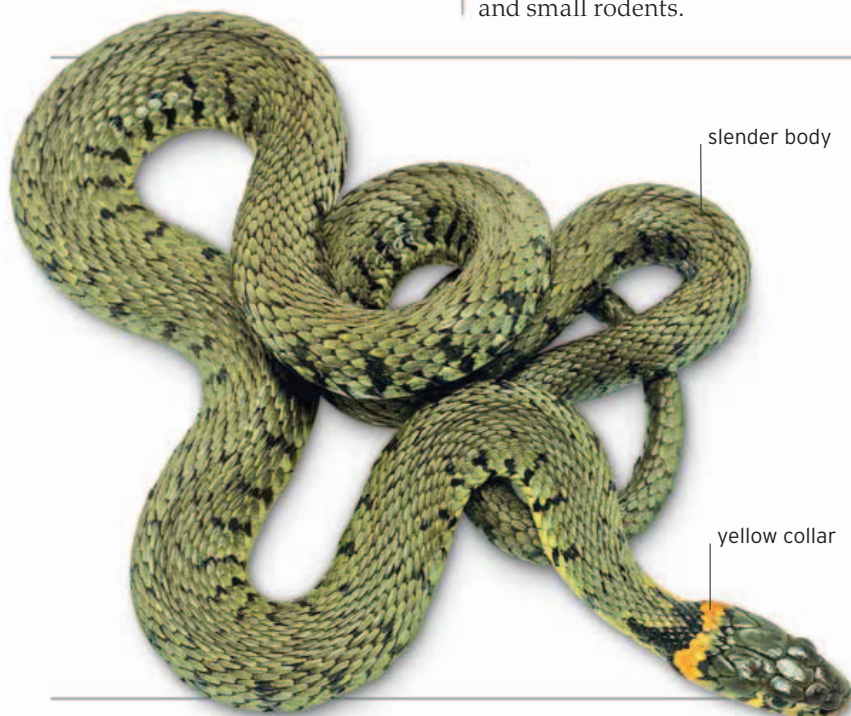


Common kingsnake

Lampropeltis getula

- ↔ 3–7 ft (1–2.1 m)
- 📍 W. and S. US, N. Mexico
- ⊗ Common

Closely allied to milksnakes, this nonvenomous snake is harmless to humans—but is a formidable predator of small animals. It hunts warm-blooded mammals and birds, entering rodent burrows and killing the occupants by constriction. It also preys on amphibians and other reptiles—even venomous snakes. It is largely immune to their venom and may subdue them by biting down onto their jaws.



European grass snake

Natrix natrix

- ↔ 4–7 ft (1.2–2.1 m)
- 📍 Europe to C. Asia, NW. Africa
- ⊗ Common

Widespread in open woodland and grasslands of Europe, this snake neither uses venom to kill prey nor constricts them—it swallows them alive. The snake targets amphibians, such as frogs, and stays close to their wetland habitat. It can also swim well. It rarely bites except when hunting; if molested by predators, it plays dead and releases a foul-smelling fluid from its anal glands.

Brown house snake

Boaedon capensis

- ↔ 3–4 ft (1–1.2 m)
- 📍 S. Africa
- ⊗ Not known

House snakes—so called because of their fondness for entering buildings—are nonvenomous African snakes. They may bite if provoked, but are harmless to humans. It may be tan, brown, orange, or black with cream stripes on the sides of its head. It constricts and kills small mammals and may be significant in the control of mice and rats in towns and villages.

Australian copperhead

Austrelaps superbus

- ↔ 4–6 ft (1.2–1.8 m)
- 📍 SE. Australia, N. Tasmania
- ⊗ Not known

This elapid snake—a relative of cobras and mambas—thrives in cool parts of eastern Australia. It is often seen flattening its body, perhaps as a way of increasing absorption of the sun's heat—but can stay active in lower temperatures where other snakes are dormant. Like other elapids, it has dangerously potent venom, but mainly hunts cold-blooded prey, such as amphibians, which it targets in wetland habitats.

Yellow-lipped sea krait

Laticauda colubrina

- ↔ 3–7 ft (1–2.1 m)
- 📍 S. and SE. Asia
- ⊗ Common

Although oceangoing in habit, the yellow-lipped sea krait is less well adapted to an aquatic life than other sea snakes. It returns to shore to lay eggs, whereas most other sea snakes give birth to live young in the ocean. Its large belly scales help it to grip land. This sea krait is common on coral reefs, where it hunts at night using powerful venom to kill fish—particularly eels. However, it is very reluctant to bite humans.



South American coral snake

Micrurus lemniscatus

- ↔ 24–35 in (61–89 cm)
- 📍 N. and C. South America
- ⊗ Common

Around 80 species of American coral snakes have their greatest diversity in the South American tropics. Each has a body pattern of vibrant red, yellow, and black bands—a warning that the venom of these front-fanged snakes is very potent. The South American coral snake is one of the most widespread coral snakes, but—like others—it is a shy ground-dweller that spends part of the day in a burrow and hunts other reptiles.